

Dmitri Kochelarov

CEO & Co-founder, [FrontSail AI](#) ↗ (frontsail.ai)

Zero to one, four times over. Firmware, a cloud platform, AI agents. Now an agentic OS for small business.

Whoever ships a feature owns the whole of it, from the first bit of research out to production. I learned that at Jungo, where there was nobody else to do the work, and later built a 20-person R&D org around it. Eighteen years on, I still write code most days.



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4× ZERO TO ONE 1 → 20+ ENGINEERS 2 months TO A SHIPPED AGENT SOC 2 AT ENTERPRISE SCALE

WORK

CEO & Co-founder, [FrontSail AI](#) ↗ (frontsail.ai)

Nov 2025 to now

An agentic operating system for small business. It takes the repetitive back-office work off the owner's plate so they can get back to running the place.

- Founded with two partners. The platform is live, with small businesses using it across Canada and the US.
- Two product lines out in seven months: an AI phone receptionist in January 2026, back-office automation in June 2026.
- Still early. We are building for the segment most software companies skip, because the contracts look too small to bother with.

Founding Software Engineer, [Starboard](#) ↗ (starboard.biz)

Feb to Dec 2025

AI agents that let freight forwarders run and scale operations without adding headcount.

- Joined when the company was three people. Shipped the first freight-forwarder agent in two months, and clients were using it daily by month six.
- This was March 2025, before the primitives existed. Session handling, auth, security, reliability: we worked out our own answers to all of it, on models that would cheerfully hallucinate in front of a paying customer.
- Shipped an Outlook add-in that reads rate sheets, pulls data out of PDFs and spreadsheets, and drafts replies to RFQs. Python and GCP behind it.
- Stack: OpenAI and Gemini, Agent SDK, Python, TypeScript, React, Supabase, Upstash Redis, Elasticsearch, GCP.

Staff Software Engineer, [Klue](#) ↗ (klue.com)

Sep 2024 to Feb 2025

Data quality for the AI pipeline behind competitive insights. A deliberate step back into an IC role.

- Integrated CRM and public web sources, then redesigned the core data models and pipelines so the ML models had wider and cleaner input to work from.
 - Stack: Python, TypeScript, React, OpenAI, Perplexity, Elasticsearch, Kubernetes, GCP.
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Technical R&D Director, [Planitar ↗](#) (goiguide.com)

Jun 2014 to Aug 2024

First engineer → 20+ person R&D org behind the [iGUIDE](#) (goiguide.com), Canada's leading 3D virtual tour platform.

- Hired as the first engineer to turn a prototype into a product. Built the image-processing pipeline, the cloud infrastructure and the customer portal that became iGUIDE.
- Grew and ran the whole R&D org, 20+ engineers across several teams. Hiring was the hard part: Kitchener-Waterloo during COVID, competing with American companies who had no budget ceiling, while I very much did.
- Owned product direction alongside architecture until we hired our first product manager in 2022.
- Stood up a UX design function, and an ML research team of scientists and engineers who automated our internal drafting work with deep learning.
- Go and Node microservices on AWS, orchestrated with Docker, CoreOS, Nomad and Terraform. We reached SOC 2 and high availability for enterprise customers: BGIS, who manage facilities for the Government of Canada, insurance partners SeekNow and Colonial Claims, and municipalities across the US and Canada.
- Ran the org on the same rule I grew up with at Jungo, which mostly meant hiring people willing to learn a domain rather than specialists who wanted a lane.
- The org still runs today, two years after I left. That is the part I am proudest of.

Embedded Software Engineer, [Jungo ↗](#) (jungo.com)

Sep 2008 to Dec 2013

Portable, hardware-agnostic firmware for residential routers. Netanya, Israel; later acquired by Cisco.

- Everyone did everything. Bootloaders one week, Wi-Fi kernel drivers the next, then the orchestration logic, then the HTML and JavaScript config UI. This is where the habit comes from.
- Led the Vodafone 3G/LTE module, which was territory nobody at the company had touched. I researched the domain, turned Vodafone's requirements into an architecture that fit our hardware-agnostic firmware, and shipped it.
- It brought connectivity to mountainous and rural regions, Italy among them, where fixed infrastructure was thin. It shipped in VOX 1.5 and 2.0 gateways across Europe.
- Stack: C/C++, JavaScript, Linux kernel, drivers, bootloaders.

ALONGSIDE

[Cosmic Lift ↗](#) (cosmic-lift.com) • Jan 2025 to now

My consulting practice. Fractional CTO work, training, and product architecture and development for companies going AI-first, or making what they already have AI-ready.

TOOLS I'M FLUENT IN

AI: OpenAI and Gemini, Agent SDKs, retrieval, document extraction, evals, agent reliability.
Languages: Go, Python, TypeScript/JavaScript, C/C++, Bash.
Infra: AWS, GCP, Docker, Nomad, Kubernetes, Terraform, Postgres, Redis, Elasticsearch.
Front end: React, Vue, AngularJS.

HOW I WORK

- Range beats specialization on a small team. I hire for curiosity and let people pick up the domain on the job.
- I stay in the code. That did not change when I started running an org, and it has not changed now.
- Learning a new domain is part of the job, not a prerequisite for it. Firmware, 3D imaging, freight, agents: none of them were mine to start with.
- I would rather ship something small that works than something large that demos well.

EDUCATION

B.Sc. Computer Software Engineering

Technion, Israel Institute of Technology ↗ (technion.ac.il/en), Haifa

2006 to 2012